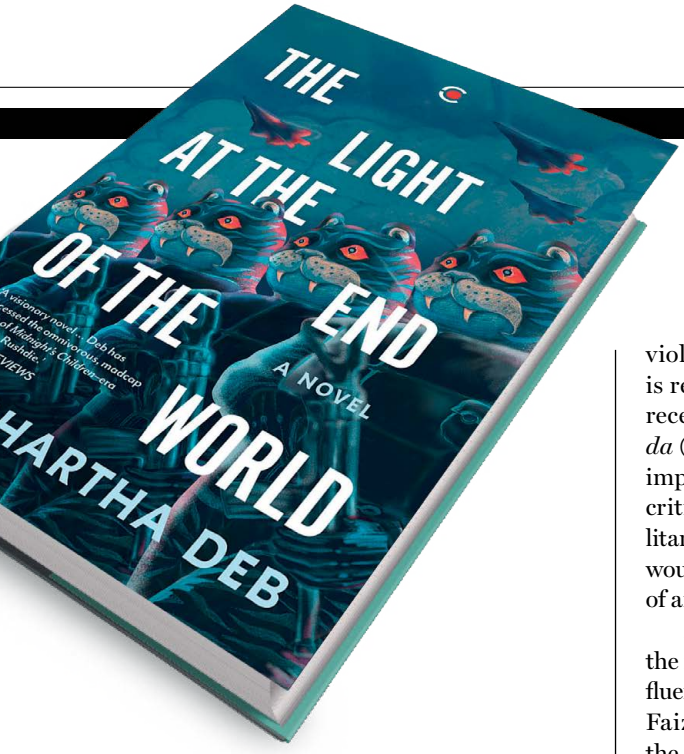


THE LIGHT AT THE END OF THE WORLD: A Novel
by Siddhartha Deb
WESTLAND
₹799; 458 pages

reference for granular history. This distance allows *The Light at the End of the World* to escape the trap that its subject matter might lead it towards—that is, the trap of becoming polemical or didactic.

The interposition of the fictional point of view, alongside the structural and granular violence that is at the heart of the book, is reminiscent of Shehan Karunatilaka's recent *The Seven Moons of Maali Almeida* (2020). Here, the distancing plays the important role of opening up the reader's critical faculties, without which the grim litany of deaths, murders and assassinations would turn numbing—to statistics, instead of art, as Joseph Brodsky might observe.

In the Acknowledgments at the end of the novel, Deb lists out some of his own influences—from W.H. Auden to Faiz Ahmed Faiz to reports on the Bengal Famine to the science fiction novels of the Strugatsky Brothers. This is a fascinating window into the author's mind, and enriches the readers' understanding of the novel; it also, however, gestures towards something else. The variety and the profusion of characters, locations, events and callbacks that populate the pages of *The Light at the End of the World* are such that it borders on being overwhelming, at times. One almost wishes that one had a little more time with one scene, to allow it to seep into one's bones, before the story moved on to the next scene, and the next reference. The tale of India, after all, is best told slowly. ■

Gautam Bhatia

A striking effect that Deb achieves in his book is a simultaneous nearness-and-distancing from its subject matter



extraordinary in his milieu. Where his wife is ambitious, his son wants to drop out of school to make money, his cousin is raking it in, and his principal at school is motivated by her limited version of history, Alif's acceptance of the contradictions around him makes him stand out.

History's Angel—the title is a nod to Walter Benjamin's essay on the concept of history—is a story of choices and of the tension between action and thought working independently of each other.

"Your time is up," a passing boy tells Alif's friend when they are together. It might have been said to Alif—that would depend on the boy's religion, a brilliant shadow of coming events.

What happens to any one of us happens to all of us—and what is universal is, equally, personal. Anjum Hasan, one of our most accomplished writers, deals with this complementarity with writing that is lyrical, nuanced, restrained and humorous.

Ganesh, Alif's drinking buddy, opens a door to a more personal past to let in a woman both loved in college. As Benjamin wrote, nothing that happened should be regarded as lost for history.

Do you know when an event becomes of historical value? asks Alif, and answers, "When we are able to remind ourselves of its unexpectedness." He is not all theory and thought—he is proud of his new shoes, and when they get uncomfortable on his long walks, that becomes the focus.

History's Angel is **a story of choices** and the tension between action and thought working independently of each other

Perhaps, as the author says, we aren't interested in any history that doesn't concern us directly.

It is tempting to see *History's Angel* as a political or even a philosophical novel, but that would be limiting its scope. Hasan's command of expressions of ordinariness, ambivalence and power equations layers it with possibilities that reward multiple readings. Her intelligence and depth seen in early novels *Neti, Neti* and *The Cosmopolitans* have been employed in the service of the story. Lesser writers might have done the reverse, using the novel as an excuse for spouting philosophy. This is not just an important novel, but a necessary one for our times. ■

Suresh Menon